

Brighton and the Cotswolds

~ A Family Adventure ~

Middle Explorer Edition - Ages 9-12
Summer 2026

PASSPORT PAGES - The world is their story.

Welcome, Adventurers!

Welcome to Britain! You are about to explore a country packed with more history, weirdness, and wonder per square mile than almost anywhere on Earth. This book is your guide to all the secret stories hiding in the places you will visit.

Before we start, a few things to keep in mind:

- England is smaller than Louisiana but has over 1,000 years of castle history.
- The British drive on the LEFT. Look right, then left before crossing!
- The UK is made of four countries: England, Scotland, Wales, and Northern Ireland.
- Over 30 million people visit the UK each year. Soon, that includes YOU!

Brighton - London-by-the-Sea

The Pebble Beach Surprise

Here is something that surprises almost everyone: Brighton Beach does not have sand. It is covered in millions of smooth, round PEBBLES. When the tide comes in, the waves make a strange, rattling sound as they pull the stones back. It is called the shingle music and people come from all over just to hear it.

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The Palace Pier - A Victorian Theme Park

Brighton Palace Pier opened in 1899. It is 1,760 feet long - exactly one-third of a mile. During WWII, the pier was closed and the middle section was REMOVED to stop enemy boats from landing on it.

The Royal Pavilion - A Palace from a Fairy Tale

King George IV built this bizarre, beautiful palace in the early 1800s. It looks like an Indian temple but is decorated inside like a Chinese emperor's palace. The dining room table could seat 80 people and was designed so servants could raise and lower the table through a trapdoor to swap courses without being seen!

Oxford - The City of Dreaming Spires

Lunch at The Bear Inn (Est. 1242)

The Bear Inn claims to be Oxford's oldest pub, built in 1242. That is over 780 years ago! It opened just 27 years after the Magna Carta was signed. University students have been eating here since before Shakespeare was born.

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Punting

Punting along the river with a punter. Dates back to the 17th century. Pronounced 'pun-ting'.

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The Bodleian Library

Founded in 1602, the Bodleian has over 13 MILLION books stored across 80 miles of shelves. For centuries, any book published in the UK must be given to the Bodleian for free. That is the law. Every book you have ever read in Britain is probably sitting somewhere in those underground tunnels.

The Cotswolds - Golden Treasure

Moreton-in-Marsh and The Tuesday Market

Every Tuesday, the High Street transforms into the biggest street market in the Cotswolds. Over 200 stalls sell local produce, antiques, and artisan goods. This tradition dates back to 1226, when King Henry III granted the town a charter. For 800 YEARS, people have been gathering here every Tuesday!

Bibury - The Most Beautiful Village

Arlington Row - The Passport Cottages

These honey-colored stone cottages were built in 1380 as a wool store. Monks stored their wool here before selling it across Europe. In the 1600s, they were turned into weavers' cottages. Today, they appear on the INSIDE COVER of every single UK passport.

Diddly Squat and Stow-on-the-Wold

St Edward's Church - The Doors of Durin?

The north door of St Edward's Church is framed by two ancient yew trees whose gnarled roots arch over the entrance like a doorway from a fantasy novel. Many visitors say it looks like the Doors of Durin from Lord of the Rings. The church dates to before 1086. It is mentioned in the Domesday Book!

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Diddly Squat Farm Shop

Jeremy Clarkson bought a farm in the Cotswolds in 2008 and discovered he had NO IDEA how to run it. The TV show Clarkson's Farm follows his hilarious failures. The name Diddly Squat means, well, nothing at all - which is what Clarkson knew about farming when he started!

Bourton-on-the-Water

Known as the Venice of the Cotswolds for its low stone bridges spanning the shallow River Windrush. Five stone bridges have been here for over 200 years.

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Stratford-upon-Avon - Shakespeare

The Boy from Stratford

William Shakespeare was born here in 1564. He went to the local grammar school where he studied Latin, Greek, and rhetoric. His classroom STILL EXISTS. He invented over 1,700 words we still use, including: eyeball, gossip, bedroom, lonely, and swagger.

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Broadway Tower - A Folly with a View

This 65-foot tower sits on the second-highest point of the Cotswolds at 1,024 feet. It was built in 1798 by Capability Brown. From the top, you can see 16 counties on a clear day!

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Castle Combe - The Prettiest Village

Often called the prettiest village in England. It has no traffic lights, no street lamps (gas lamps instead), and looks exactly like a medieval village. The market cross in the center has stood there since the 14th century.

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Quick-Fire Fun Facts

Brighton Beach

Covered in millions of pebbles, not sand. The waves make a shingle music sound.

**Brighton Palace Pier
Royal Pavilion**

1,760 feet long. Middle section removed during WWII to stop enemy boats.
King George IV built it - looks Indian outside, Chinese inside. Just because he could.

**Oxford University
Bodleian Library**

Over 900 years old. Older than the Aztec Empire. Older than the printing press.
13 million books across 80 miles of shelves.

Arlington Row

Built 1380 as a wool store. On every UK passport.

St Edward Church

Mentioned in the Domesday Book (1086). North door looks like Doors of Durin.

Clarkson Farm

Jeremy Clarkson had no idea what he was doing. Farming is HARD.

Shakespeare

Born 1564. Invented 1,700+ words. Classroom still exists.

Broadway Tower

65-foot tower at 1,024 feet elevation. Cold War bunker inside.

Castle Combe

Prettiest village in England. No traffic lights. Film sets love it.